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Setting Sail

The First Ripples

Now to return to the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company.

A few weeks after the brief notice in *The Hindu* about the first stirrings of the Swadeshi movement, the first steamer leased by the Swadeshi merchants, *Shah Amere* arrived at Tuticorin on 10 April 1906. The Criminal Investigation Department (CID) of the Madras Police reported that some 'native merchants' of Tuticorin were arranging to run 'some *swadeshi* steamers between Tuticorin and Ceylon to compete with the British India steamers' with the firm of Essaji Tajbhoy of Bombay.[1]

Essaji Tajbhoy, 'a respected Borah' Muslim merchant who had made a name for himself and much money in his shipbuilding business at Darow Khana (Dharukhana), had purchased an old Peninsular and Oriental Steam Navigation (P&O) steamer around 1901 to establish the Shah Line Company.[2] The leasing of steamers from Shah Line Company by the Tuticorin merchants was the genesis of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company (SSNCo). The relationship proved to be a roller-coaster ride, causing much grief to the Swadeshi company. But we are getting ahead of the story.

On receiving CID intelligence about the arrival of the Swadeshi steamer, the collector and district magistrate[3] of Tirunelveli remarked, 'I do not think any arrangement has been, or is likely to be, come to.' Cynically, he added that 'the business venture appears to be called *swadeshi* only to attract custom'.[4] Few civil servants are prescient, especially in relation to popular politics; this particular collector, D.D. Murdoch, was no exception. As the events of the next two years would show, the district collector's remark was way off the mark.